



BEFORE

A great age of world exploration began in the 1400s, and lasted for over 400 years.

EARLY MAPPING

At the beginning of the 15th century, European sailors used maps based on the writings of ancient Greek geographer **Ptolemy**, showing Europe, the Mediterranean, and western Asia. The voyages of explorers such as **Christopher Columbus** << 228–29 and **Ferdinand Magellan** << 224–25 were instrumental in helping cartographers more accurately map the globe. However, European knowledge of the Southern Hemisphere was still sketchy. A Dutch



1486 ENGRAVING OF PTOLEMY MAP

map from the late 1500s shows an area labeled **Terra Australis Nondum Cognita** (“not yet known southern land”): it was thought Earth’s land was equal in size north and south of the equator.

BRITISH EXPLORER (1728–79)

CAPTAIN JAMES COOK

One of five children, James Cook was born in Yorkshire, northern England, the son of a farm-hand. Apprenticed into the Merchant Navy, Cook studied astronomy and navigation and, after joining the British Royal Navy in 1755, made a name charting parts of Canada during the Seven Years War (see pp.296–97). He led three voyages to the Pacific, and was greatly respected by his crew, believing in good diet and hygiene. Despite mainly successful efforts to forge friendly relations with the Polynesians he visited, Cook was killed in Hawaii in 1779.



Completing the Map

Led by the desire to discover new land and lay claim to its riches, to open trade routes, or simply in a spirit of adventure, explorers of the 18th and 19th centuries mapped the continents of Australia, Africa, and North America, and set out to conquer the poles.

The continuing belief in the mid-18th century was that some vast southern continent must exist south of the equator to balance the Asian landmass in the north (see BEFORE). In 1768, Captain James Cook’s reputation as a cartographer earned him the leadership of a British expedition

to the Pacific. With instructions to chart coastlines and annex trading posts in the name of the British Crown, Cook’s first Pacific voyage (1768–71) took him around New Zealand and along the coast of eastern Australia. Matthew Flinders later



Cook’s chronometer, K1, 1769

Invented by John Harrison, the chronometer (see p.282) allowed the measurement of longitude. Cook was one of the first to know his exact position while sailing uncharted waters.

circumnavigated Australia (1801–03), proving it was one large island. The west coast Swan River colony, founded in 1829, confirmed British claims to the whole continent,

but few ventured deep into the interior until 1860, when Robert Burke and John Wills left Melbourne and headed north. By the following year they had crossed Australia.

Into Africa

Africa posed a great challenge to explorers, as there were still many blank spaces in European maps of the continent. The British, Portuguese, French, and Germans were all eager to lay claim to its lands, with various religious, commercial, political, and colonial agendas. Major exploration of Africa’s interior began when a Scot, Mungo Park, traveled in the Niger Valley (1796–1805). Later in the 19th century several explorers, including Richard Burton,

